

Middle East Daily Brief

July 3, 2026

Executive summary

14 stories from 8 outlets (6 perspectives) over the reporting window. Leading the day: Iran prepares massive state funeral for slain Supreme Leader Khamenei, July 4-9.

Top stories

1. **Iran prepares massive state funeral for slain Supreme Leader Khamenei, July 4-9** *CNN, CBS News, Middle East Eye, NBC News, The Hill* · corroborated by 5 outlets Iran is preparing multi-day funeral ceremonies for Ali Khamenei, killed in an airstrike on the war's first day (Feb 28), running July 4-9 across Tehran, Qom and Mashhad in Iran and Najaf and Karbala in Iraq. Officials expect 15-20 million... <https://www.cnn.com/2026/07/02/world/live-news/iran-war-us-talks>
2. **US-Iran indirect talks in Doha make 'positive progress'; next round set for July 18 after Khamenei funeral** *Al Arabiya, Al Jazeera, Arab News, CBS News, Middle East Eye* · corroborated by 5 outlets Qatar-mediated indirect talks between US and Iranian negotiators wrapped up in Doha with 'positive progress' on issues tied to the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding, per Qatar's foreign ministry. Al Arabiya sources say an initial... <https://english.alarabiya.net/News/middle-east/2026/07/02/next-indirect-usiran-talks-after-khamenei-funeral-mediators>
3. **Syria and Lebanon form joint ministerial committee; Damascus 'open to meeting Hezbollah'** *Arab News, The Jerusalem Post, The Times of Israel* · corroborated by 3 outlets Syrian FM Asaad Al-Shaibani and Lebanese PM Nawaf Salam signed an agreement in Beirut establishing a joint ministerial committee on security coordination and economic cooperation. During the visit, Al-Shaibani said Damascus is open to... <https://www.arabnews.com/node/2649424/middle-east>
4. **US indirectly warned Iran that Israel might try to kill its top negotiators during war-ending talks, NYT reports** *The Times of Israel, The New York Times* · corroborated by 2 outlets Citing a New York Times report, US officials indirectly warned Iranian FM Abbas Araghchi and parliament speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf during the war-ending negotiations that Israel might attempt to assassinate them. https://www.timesofisrael.com/liveblog_entry/during-talks-on-ending-war-us-indirectly-warned-iran-that-israel-may-try-to-kill-its-top-negotiators-nyt-report/
5. **Israel marks 1,000 days since October 7; thousands at Hostages Square demand commission of inquiry** *The Times of Israel, The Jerusalem Post* · corroborated by 2 outlets Israel marked 1,000 days since the October 7, 2023 attack with memorial ceremonies and protests. Thousands gathered at Hostages Square in Tel Aviv demanding a state commission of inquiry; protesters also demonstrated outside the Knesset... <https://www.timesofisrael.com/liveblog-july-2-2026/>
6. **US tells Tehran it rejects any changes to Strait of Hormuz status quo** *Al Arabiya, Middle East Eye* · corroborated by 2 outlets After the Doha talks concluded, Washington sent Tehran

clear messages rejecting any change to the current status quo in the Strait of Hormuz, saying any change would be considered a violation of the agreement, per Al Arabiya sources. Iran... <https://english.alarabiya.net/News/middle-east/2026/07/02/us-informed-tehran-of-its-rejection-to-any-changes-in-strait-of-hormuz-al-arabiya-sources>

By theme

Israel – Gaza & the Palestinians

- **Israel marks 1,000 days since October 7; thousands at Hostages Square demand commission of inquiry** – The Times of Israel, The Jerusalem Post <https://www.timesofisrael.com/liveblog-july-2-2026/>
- **Gaza war's 1,000 days: 90% of strip 'destroyed', 80% 'seized' by Israel** – Al Jazeera, Middle East Monitor <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/7/2/gaza-wars-1000-days-90-of-strip-destroyed-80-seized-by-israel>
- **Hamas calls for emergency Arab summit over alleged Gaza displacement plans** – Middle East Monitor <https://www.middleeastmonitor.com/20260702-hamas-calls-for-emergency-arab-summit-over-alleged-gaza-displacement-plans/>
- **Trump's Board of Peace says UNRWA has 'no place' in new Gaza** – Middle East Eye <https://www.middleeasteye.net/news/trumps-board-peace-says-unrwa-has-no-place-gaza>
- **B'Tselem: 54 Palestinian children killed in West Bank in 2025 'not isolated incidents'** – Arab News <https://www.arabnews.com/node/2649455/middle-east>

Iran & the US

- **Iran prepares massive state funeral for slain Supreme Leader Khamenei, July 4-9** – CNN, CBS News, Middle East Eye, NBC News, The Hill <https://www.cnn.com/2026/07/02/world/live-news/iran-war-us-talks>
- **US indirectly warned Iran that Israel might try to kill its top negotiators during war-ending talks, NYT reports** – The Times of Israel, The New York Times https://www.timesofisrael.com/liveblog_entry/talks-on-ending-war-us-indirectly-warned-iran-that-israel-may-try-to-kill-its-top-negotiators-nyt-report/
- **US tells Tehran it rejects any changes to Strait of Hormuz status quo** – Al Arabiya, Middle East Eye <https://english.alarabiya.net/News/middle-east/2026/07/02/us-informed-tehran-of-its-rejection-to-any-changes-in-strait-of-hormuz-al-arabiya-sources>
- **Strait of Hormuz to remain 'Warlike Operations Area' until at least July 9; unions warn of seafarer risk** – Middle East Eye, RFE/RL <https://www.middleeasteye.net/live-blog/live-blog-update/seafarers-face-significant-risk-strait-hormuz-unions-say>

Lebanon & Hezbollah

- **IDF says strike killed Hezbollah operative who emerged from tunnel in south Lebanon** – The Times of Israel <https://www.timesofisrael.com/idf-says-strike-killed-hezbollah-operative-who-emerged-from-tunnel-in-south-lebanon/>

Syria & Iraq

- **Syria and Lebanon form joint ministerial committee; Damascus 'open to meeting Hezbollah'** — Arab News, The Jerusalem Post, The Times of Israel <https://www.arabnews.com/node/2649424/middle-east>
- **Bomb blast at Damascus cafe kills five, injures 16** — The Jerusalem Post, Al Jazeera <https://www.jpost.com/middle-east/article-901243>

Gulf & Arabian Peninsula

- **US-Iran indirect talks in Doha make 'positive progress'; next round set for July 18 after Khamenei funeral** — Al Arabiya, Al Jazeera, Arab News, CBS News, Middle East Eye <https://english.alarabiya.net/News/middle-east/2026/07/02/next-indirect-usiran-talks-after-khamenei-funeral-mediators>

Israel – politics & society

- **Israel and US launch talks on new defense framework to replace 10-year security MoU** — The Jerusalem Post <https://www.jpost.com/defense-and-tech/article-901207>

Perspective balance

Perspective	Stories
Israeli	5
Saudi	4
independent	2
international	1
Qatari	1
pro-Palestinian	1

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